

ExPatLit.com

A Literary Review for Writers Abroad

Summer and Fall
2010



as American as apple pie

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Food is central to the human experience, and a lot more influential than we probably realize. Think about it: in an average week, how much time do you spend planning, discussing, purchasing, preparing, and consuming food? (And don't forget about the dishes.)

But there's more to dining than what goes on your plate; it's also about who sits with you at the table. So much of our socializing revolves around food: meeting a friend for coffee, maneuvering our way through a second-date dinner, making sure our kids have six dozen brownies for the marching band bake sale. The office manager seeking to entice his employees to attend "optional" stress-management seminars makes sure to mention refreshments in the memo. If you serve it, they will come. Food is a force that draws all kinds of people together. If it's true that you are what you eat, then doesn't it follow that people who nosh together will have something in common? Maybe eating on the go really is the reason for the alleged breakdown of the modern family.

Of course, having dinner with your family is kind of difficult when you live in different countries. So, when it comes to those really important meals of the year—for an American, Thanksgiving and Christmas—those of us who live abroad tend to eat with friends. These could be expats or locals, possibly some of each. Everyone gathers together, probably potluck-style, and you all do your best to recreate the kind of meal you'd be enjoying if you were at home.

I spent my first year abroad teaching English on Jeju-do, a little island just south of the Korean peninsula. When it came around to Thanksgiving, a bunch of us Western teachers decided we needed to celebrate. Greg and Kim, a couple who worked with me, offered to host. Of course we had to work on *the day of*, but Saturday after Thanksgiving we rendezvoused at their apartment. There were fifteen of us altogether: eight Americans, four Canadians, two English, and one Korean. For Rob and Marian (the English couple) and Master Oh (our martial arts instructor), this was to be their first Thanksgiving ever. As the local cooking enthusiast, I was determined to do the dinner properly—well, as close to proper as we could come—right down to the pie for dessert.

They don't sell Sara Lee pastries in Korea, so if I wanted a pie, I would have to make it from scratch, crust and all. Though pumpkin pie is traditional, I decided to go with apple. It takes a lot of work to process raw pumpkin into pie filling: peel, dice, boil, mash, season. Actually, I wouldn't have minded, except that I was already in charge of the stuffing, two pans of green bean casserole, and something like twenty chicken breasts (no turkeys around). Why had I ended up with so much work? I was the only one with an oven. And by oven, I mean toaster oven.

Most Korean kitchens don't feature ovens by default because baked goods aren't a big part of the traditional cuisine. It's the same in Japan and China and some other Asian countries. It is possible to buy a proper oven, but the ones you find tend to be small and very expensive. Toaster ovens are a more sensible alternative, especially if they're only going to be used occasionally. Well, Thanksgiving qualifies as occasional, right, since it only comes once a year?

Me, I was lucky. I'd inherited my toaster oven from Sam and Ciara, a couple who left the island not too long after I arrived. They'd been given the toaster by another couple, who'd gotten it from somebody else...in a small place like Jeju, these kinds of valuables tend to get passed around. It's funny; an oven isn't the kind of thing you think much about until you find yourself without one. I was ecstatic when Sam brought it over. The toaster oven was a squat little box painted a retro shade of red-orange, and it had obviously been well used. That same day, I invited Greg and Kim over for dinner: marinated chicken breasts baked in foil packets with onions and peppers. Nothing fancy, but it sure tasted good.

In the weeks leading up to Thanksgiving, I used the oven for a number of recipes, but none were as ambitious as a pie. Since you've probably not had the opportunity to bake an apple pie in a toaster oven, let me walk you through the process. First, you need to compile the necessary ingredients: flour, butter, baking [powder], salt, white sugar, brown sugar, apples, lemon juice, cinnamon and spices. Depending on how well-stocked your pantry is, you'll probably need to make a shopping trip. Also, you'll need to have measuring cups and spoons. I was glad I'd brought mine with me, since Korea is metric rather than imperial.

You begin with crust dough. Combine the flour, butter, baking [powder], sugar, a pinch of salt and a little ice water, and blend until the mixture resembles coarse crumbs. The easiest way to do this is in a food processor. However, since mine was about seven thousand miles away, I made do with a blender. It took five or six rounds to get it all

mixed (it was a small blender), but there has to be enough for a top and a bottom crust. Next, the dough must be flattened with a rolling pin: do this between pieces of plastic wrap so the crusts retain their round shape. Then, chill in the fridge for at least an hour. While you're waiting, you can prepare the apples: peel, core, slice, and toss with lemon juice, brown sugar, and spices. You will also need to preheat the oven to 400 F (200 C). However, since a toaster oven is about the size of a shoebox, that doesn't take very long, and so you can wait to do this until the pie's ready to go.

When the crusts have chilled, carefully peel away the plastic wrap. Fit one crust to a pie pan, allowing about a half inch of dough to hang over the edge. Add the apples and dot with butter. Gently place the second crust over the filling and crimp the edges to seal the crusts together. Using a sharp knife, pierce a few ventilation slits. Finally, put the pie in the oven and bake for [ninety] minutes. Now, under normal circumstances the goal is to have a golden brown crust, but with a toaster oven, you're mostly hoping for 'not black'. Rotating the pan a quarter-turn every fifteen minutes or so may help to avoid this, but I make no guarantees.

Finally the pie was done. As I pulled it out of the oven, I mentally chanted a mantra: *Please don't be burned, please don't be burned*. The pie *looked* good, and it *smelled* great, but there was no way to know if the bottom was charred. There wasn't time to worry about it now—the green bean casseroles and chicken still had to be baked. The poor oven, it didn't have a chance to cool down before the next pan was in. All in all, I think we ran the toaster for about seven hours straight. More than once I said to Kim, "This thing's not going to make it. It's going to burn out for sure." But this was a brave little toaster oven. It didn't burn out, and it didn't burn the chicken or the beans. I could only hope the pie had fared as well.

Dinner was lovely. Between the fifteen of us, we'd put together a massive spread, and all of the food was wonderful. Finally, it was time for dessert. I sliced into the pie and gingerly lifted out the first piece. *Don't be burned, please don't be burned!* On examination, I found it fragrant, flaky, and flawless. I was so shocked, I nearly dropped the thing. Fortunately, Rob came to the rescue with his plate. As I mentioned, this was his first Thanksgiving dinner, and so far things were going well—he'd managed to finish three helpings of mains. But this was the gold medal round. All of us who were in the kitchen waited expectantly as he took a bite. Rob slowly chewed, and swallowed... and then this huge grin broke out across his face.

"This is *amazing*! Marian, you've got to try this pie!"

Everyone had a piece, and everyone agreed it was great. But I don't think anyone enjoyed their pie as much as me, not even Rob. It wasn't just about a cook taking pride in her own culinary accomplishment. No, this was something far more significant. From then on, whenever Rob or Marian or Master Oh would hear someone mention Thanksgiving, they would remember that meal, the meal I'd helped prepare. Thanks to the little toaster that could, they would forever associate my country's holiday with my apple pie. I don't think I've ever felt more patriotic.

That toaster oven served me well over the course of the year. In addition to two more apple pies, it baked muffins, bread, quiche, pizza, potatoes, and I don't know what all else. Maybe it sounds silly, but for me cooking became a way to preserve my sanity. It wasn't that I disliked Korean food. On the contrary, I like Korean food more than a lot of foreigners who've tried it. But the thing is, no matter how adventurous your palate may be, when you've spent long enough immersed in a completely different culture, eventually you find yourself wishing for a taste of home. That's the real meaning of comfort food: it's something you love because it's something you *know*.

Now I live in Scotland, a place where full-sized ovens are standard kitchen equipment. I haven't baked any pies recently; without a toaster oven, there's not much of a *challenge*. No, these days I spend my time trying to satisfy my cravings for steamed dumpling soup, spicy noodles with seafood, soft tofu stew...all the foods I learned to love in Korea. I keep kicking myself for not learning how to cook these things while I was there; now I have to rely on Internet recipes and trial-and-error. My flatmate is a good sport to tolerate all the unusual smells. Out of courtesy, I wait until she leaves the house before I break out the dried anchovies and kelp for soup broth.

A week or so after I first arrived here, I went to the local East Asian grocery in search of soy sauce, sticky rice, and other ingredients that had become staples in my kitchen. When I walked through the door, I found myself standing amongst the aisles of bok choy and daikon, ramen and tom yum, green tea and sesame oil—all sorts of products bearing colorful labels in a variety of languages that I don't understand.

It felt like I'd come home.